

# DFREE Platform — Hosting Analysis

Cost comparison & GoDaddy page impact · March 2026

## 1. Cost analysis — 3 hosting options

Estimated monthly totals for **early-stage traffic** (launch through moderate growth). Includes hosting, database, and email. Domain excluded — already owned.

| Option                | Estimated total (monthly) | Notes                                                   |
|-----------------------|---------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|
| AWS Amplify           | \$15–\$70                 | Good AWS fit. Aligns with SES email. Pay-as-you-go.     |
| GoDaddy VPS           | \$45–\$90                 | Works if server is managed. Higher setup & maintenance. |
| Vercel (1 seat)       | \$25–\$60                 | Best fit for Next.js. Lowest effort.                    |
| GoDaddy shared cPanel | N/A                       | Not compatible with this application.                   |

## Cost breakdown (how totals are made up)

| Option          | Hosting   | DB + email | Estimated total |
|-----------------|-----------|------------|-----------------|
| AWS Amplify     | \$5–\$45  | \$10–\$25  | \$15–\$70       |
| GoDaddy VPS     | \$35–\$65 | \$10–\$25  | \$45–\$90       |
| Vercel (1 seat) | \$20–\$35 | \$5–\$25   | \$25–\$60       |

Early-stage traffic typically sits at the lower end. Costs increase with traffic spikes, extra deploys, or additional developer seats (Vercel: +\$20/seat).

|                            | Vercel  | AWS Amplify | GoDaddy VPS   |
|----------------------------|---------|-------------|---------------|
| Setup effort               | Low     | Low         | High          |
| Ongoing maintenance        | Low     | Low         | High          |
| Per-developer seat fee     | \$20/mo | None        | None          |
| All features work reliably | Yes     | Yes         | If maintained |

**Recommendation:** Host on **Vercel** or **AWS Amplify**.

## 2. Impact by hosting option

How key **functionality** is affected on each platform. All public routes use `/en`, `/es`, or `/fr`.

Broken At risk Works

### Functionality impact summary

| Functionality                        | Vercel | AWS   | GoDaddy VPS | GoDaddy cPanel | What may be affected                         |
|--------------------------------------|--------|-------|-------------|----------------|----------------------------------------------|
| Public pages (static / marketing)    | Works  | Works | Works       | At risk        | Layout, language switching, content updates  |
| CMS content (news, projects, events) | Works  | Works | At risk     | At risk        | Articles, project listings, event filters    |
| Multi-language (EN / ES / FR)        | Works  | Works | At risk     | At risk        | Locale routing and translated pages          |
| Donations (Zeffy)                    | Works  | Works | At risk     | At risk        | Donation amounts, modals, cause cards        |
| Newsletter signup                    | Works  | Works | At risk     | Broken         | Footer and site-wide newsletter forms        |
| Fellowship application form          | Works  | Works | At risk     | Broken         | Multi-step form, uploads, confirmation email |
| Sponsorship form                     | Works  | Works | At risk     | Broken         | 3-step form, logo upload, submission email   |
| Admin dashboard & login              | Works  | Works | At risk     | Broken         | Authentication, submissions, team management |
| Confirmation & invitation emails     | Works  | Works | At risk     | Broken         | Form acknowledgements, admin invite emails   |

**GoDaddy VPS:** Features work when the server is set up and maintained correctly. They become **at risk** if the server is misconfigured, runs out of memory, or fails during a deploy.

### Page-by-page sitemap

| Page                     | Route                                          | Vercel | AWS   | VPS     | cPanel  | What may be affected                  |
|--------------------------|------------------------------------------------|--------|-------|---------|---------|---------------------------------------|
| Home & main              |                                                |        |       |         |         |                                       |
| Homepage                 | <code>/ {locale}</code>                        | Works  | Works | Works   | At risk | Layout, language switching            |
| Leadership               | <code>/ {locale} / leadership</code>           | Works  | Works | Works   | At risk | Static marketing content              |
| Contact                  | <code>/ {locale} / contact</code>              | Works  | Works | At risk | At risk | Form submission on cPanel/VPS         |
| Donate                   | <code>/ {locale} / donate</code>               | Works  | Works | At risk | At risk | Zeffy modals, cause cards             |
| Leadership Institute     |                                                |        |       |         |         |                                       |
| Institute overview       | <code>/ {locale} / leadership-institute</code> | Works  | Works | Works   | At risk | Static marketing content              |
| Fellowship application   | <code>/ ... / apply</code>                     | Works  | Works | At risk | Broken  | Form, uploads, confirmation email     |
| Sponsorship form         | <code>/ ... / sponsor</code>                   | Works  | Works | At risk | Broken  | Form, logo upload, confirmation email |
| Programs & campaigns     |                                                |        |       |         |         |                                       |
| Access Scholarships      | <code>/ ... / access-scholarships</code>       | Works  | Works | Works   | At risk | Static marketing content              |
| Billion Dollar Challenge | <code>/ ... / billion-dollar-challenge</code>  | Works  | Works | Works   | At risk | Static marketing content              |
| Community Campaigns      | <code>/ ... / community-campaigns</code>       | Works  | Works | Works   | At risk | Static marketing content              |
| FinFest                  | <code>/ ... / finfest</code>                   | Works  | Works | Works   | At risk | Static marketing content              |
| Africa                   |                                                |        |       |         |         |                                       |
| Africa overview          | <code>/ {locale} / africa</code>               | Works  | Works | At risk | At risk | CMS images & project data             |

| Page               | Route                     | Vercel | AWS   | VPS     | cPanel  | What may be affected                      |
|--------------------|---------------------------|--------|-------|---------|---------|-------------------------------------------|
| Continental pages  | /.../continental/*        | Works  | Works | Works   | At risk | Ghana, Uganda, South Africa pages         |
| All projects       | /.../projects             | Works  | Works | At risk | At risk | Project listings from CMS                 |
| Project detail     | /.../projects/[slug]      | Works  | Works | At risk | At risk | Dynamic project content                   |
| News & events      |                           |        |       |         |         |                                           |
| News listing       | /.../{locale}/news        | Works  | Works | At risk | At risk | Articles from CMS                         |
| News article       | /.../news/[slug]          | Works  | Works | At risk | At risk | Article content                           |
| Events             | /.../{locale}/events      | Works  | Works | At risk | At risk | Event listings & filters                  |
| Legal              |                           |        |       |         |         |                                           |
| Privacy policy     | /.../privacy-policy       | Works  | Works | Works   | At risk | Static legal content                      |
| Terms & conditions | /.../terms-and-conditions | Works  | Works | Works   | At risk | Static legal content                      |
| Admin              |                           |        |       |         |         |                                           |
| Admin (all pages)  | /admin/*                  | Works  | Works | At risk | Broken  | Login, submissions, team, email templates |
| Backend APIs       |                           |        |       |         |         |                                           |
| All APIs           | /api/*                    | Works  | Works | At risk | Broken  | Auth, forms, newsletter, content feeds    |

**Summary:** Vercel and AWS support the full platform. GoDaddy VPS can work but leaves forms, admin, and CMS features at risk. GoDaddy shared cPanel breaks forms and admin; static pages are only at risk.